Key terms

Martial law
Military government, with ordinary law suspended.

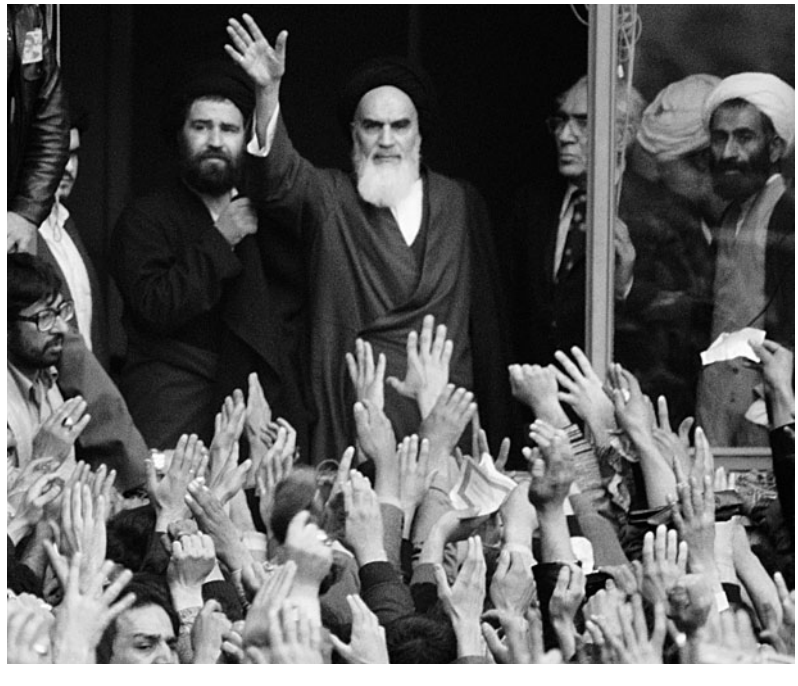
Koran
The holy book of the Muslims which, they believe, contains the word of God as conveyed to the Prophet Muhammad in the seventh century AD.

government introduced **martial law** and, the next day, troops killed over 500 people in a massive demonstration against the government. In October, there was a wave of strikes which brought most industry, including oil production, to a halt.

By the end of 1978 some soldiers were refusing to fire on crowds and some even fraternised with them, especially conscripts and those who admired Khomeini and sympathised with the protestors. Meanwhile, the Shah's advisers assured him that he was still popular and that it was only a minority of agitators who were misleading people and causing the protests. Then, in January 1979, the Shah left Iran in order to receive treatment for cancer. He never returned. Instead, the 76-year-old Khomeini returned in triumph, amid huge celebrations, and declared an Islamic Revolution. The Shah's last Prime Minister fled the country and most of the army declared support for the revolution. A national referendum produced a large majority in favour of abolishing the monarchy and establishing an Islamic republic.

The establishment of an Islamic state

Despite the huge support for the Ayatollah, there were other groups competing for power in Iran. For instance, there was the Communist Party and there were middle-class liberals who wanted a Western-style democracy. But it was Ayatollah Khomeini's supporters, organised in the Islamic Republican Party, that came to dominate the parliament and to hold the key positions in the government. Although Khomeini was not President or Prime Minister, he held ultimate power as the 'supreme leader' of Shiite Iran. He had the final say in government and law-making. New laws, based on the **Koran**, were passed; education was purged of



Ayatollah Khomeini (1902–89) was popular for his opposition to the Shah and the Shah's dependence on the USA, for his simple lifestyle and language, and his religious beliefs.